

Counting ladder rungs in one photo

Ten multimodal language models, three reasoning levels, five prompts and one rope ladder

Ginnung · runs made 2026-09-30 · 218 API calls to 10 models · total cost \$6.48

Data and scripts: <https://github.com/ginnung-tech/llm-ladder-count> (CC0) · Background article: ginnung.tech

Question. Can current general-purpose multimodal language models count the red rope steps on one rope ladder in a single photo, and does more reasoning, a different prompt, or a precise description help?

Design. One 1024×768 photo; the author counts 11 steps (12 if the white anchoring bar at the bottom is included), and any answer from 10 to 12 is scored as a hit. Experiments 1–3 ran GPT-6 Astra and Claude Opus 5.5 over reasoning levels, the number used as a format example in the prompt, the original phase-1 wording and the output cap. Experiment 4 gave ten models a long description of exactly which ladder to count and what to leave out, with maximum reasoning, high image detail and a large output budget. Each condition ran 5 times.

Results. GPT-6 Astra is consistent but too high: its median answer is 13 and 11 / 60 (18%) of its answers in experiments 1–2 are within 11 ± 1 ; it answered 11 in 0 of all its calls. Claude Opus 5.5 answers between 8 and 25, and its answers move with the example number in the prompt (median 11 with 2, 23 with 21). Raising reasoning effort did not make either model more accurate. In experiment 4, 16 / 49 (33%) valid answers across ten models are within 11 ± 1 , and only GPT-6 Astra is within tolerance in all five runs (answering 12 each time). The models' written explanations describe careful counts whether the count is right or far off.

1. Background

A first round of testing (phase 1, 2026-09-22/23), described in the background article, asked GPT-6 Astra the question in the original, informally written prompt reproduced in section 4. GPT-6 Astra answered mostly 12. Readers asked for a more rigorous follow-up: more models, several reasoning levels, prompt variations, repeated runs, and an answer to the objection that the prompt was ambiguous or sloppy. This report documents that follow-up (phase 2). All of its calls were made on 2026-09-30.

This is a small, informal experiment about one image and one question. It is not a benchmark and does not support claims about visual ability in general.

2. Test object and ground truth

The photo ([data/image/](#), public domain) shows a replica pirate ship moored at a wooden pier, seen from the pier, with the bow and bowsprit to the left. Several rope ladders (shrouds with ratlines) run from the deck up to the masts; at least five of them have red horizontal rope steps. The ladder in question is the front-most one, closest to the camera, running diagonally from the deck at the lower right, just right of the “PIRAT” name board, up to the left towards the front mast.

Ground truth. The author counts **11** red horizontal steps between a white anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot where the ladder narrows to a point at the top. Some readers count 12 by including the white bar. The scoring therefore accepts **10–12 (11 ± 1)** as a hit, which covers both readings and a one-step slip.

This tolerance was chosen after phase 1, not fixed before any data was seen. The ground truth is a single human count.

3. Method

3.1 Request settings

Setting	Value
Endpoint	OpenRouter chat completions, POST <code>https://openrouter.ai/api/v1/chat/completions</code>
Message	One user message: the prompt text first, then the image as a base64 JPEG data URL. No system prompt, no conversation history.
Reasoning	<code>reasoning: {"effort": level}</code> for low, medium, high, xhigh; for Claude models in experiment 4, <code>reasoning: {"max_tokens": 24000}</code> (a 24,000-token thinking budget).
Output cap (<code>max_tokens</code>)	low 4,000, medium 12,000, high 24,000, xhigh 32,000; experiment 3 overrides it with 2,000 / 1,000 / 100; the Gemini retry in experiment 4 used 64,000.
Image detail	<code>detail: "high"</code> for the cleaned and guided prompts; the field omitted (provider default) for the original prompt and in experiment 3, as in phase 1.
Sampling	Temperature, top-p and every other sampling setting left at provider defaults.
Accounting	<code>usage: {"include": true}</code> : the reply carries prompt, completion and reasoning tokens and the billed cost, which are stored per call.
Concurrency	5 parallel workers by default (fewer in some experiment-4 runs), the first requests started 2 s apart, conditions in a seeded random order. The seed is stored on every row.
Repeats	5 per condition. Each call is independent; nothing is cached or reused between calls.

3.2 Parsing and scoring

Every identifiable answer is counted, and any deviation from the requested format is recorded. The rules, in order (from `parse_answer` in `scripts/run_reasoning_probe.py`):

1. If the answer contains a line `COUNT: n` (the guided prompt asks for one), the last such line is the count.
2. A bare integer, optionally in backticks or followed by a full stop, is the count.
3. Otherwise, if the text contains exactly one distinct number, or one number written as an English word (zero to thirty), that is the count, noted as a deviation.
4. An empty answer or an answer with several different numbers and no `COUNT` line has no count.

In practice every non-empty answer in this data was either a bare integer or had a `COUNT` line; rules 3 and 4 were never needed except for empty answers. A count is a **hit** if it lies in 10–12. Calls that failed at the API or returned no text are reported separately and are not counted as misses.

3.3 Experiments

#	Question	Models	Prompts	Reasoning	Detail	Output cap	Calls
1	Does reasoning effort help, and does the example number in the prompt leak into the answer?	GPT-6 Astra, Claude Opus 5.5	<code>example_2</code> , <code>example_21</code> , <code>example_11</code>	low, medium, high (+ none for Astra, rejected)	high	4k / 12k / 24k	105

#	Question	Models	Prompts	Reasoning	Detail	Output cap	Calls
2	How do the models answer the original phase-1 prompt, typos included?	GPT-6 Astra, Claude Opus 5.5	original	low, medium, high	default	4k / 12k / 24k	30
3	Does a tight output budget change the answer?	GPT-6 Astra, Claude Opus 5.5	example_11	low	default	2,000 / 1,000 / 100	30
4	With every help we could give, can any model count the ladder?	10 models	guided	xhigh effort, or 24k thinking budget for Claude	high	32k (Gemini retry 64k)	53

4. Design reasoning

The design was drafted in response to criticism of phase 1 and reviewed before any call was made. The choices, and the reason for each:

- **A cleaned prompt stem.** The original prompt has typos (“horizonta”, “outlook basket”) and no question mark, which critics could blame for the answers. The stem used in experiment 1 fixes these, names the ladder as “front-most”, uses “lookout basket”, and asks a proper question. Everything else is kept short, as in phase 1.
- **The original prompt, unchanged.** Kept verbatim, typos included, with the image detail left at the default, so experiment 2 is directly comparable with phase 1. It is imported from the phase-1 script rather than copied, so it cannot drift.
- **Three example numbers.** The phrase “return only an int like `2`” shows the format, but it also puts a number next to the question. Three otherwise identical prompts use 2 (far below the true count), 21 (far above) and 11 (the true count). A model that reads the count off the image should give the same answers to all three. If answers move with the example, the example is leaking into the count. The 11 variant also asks whether handing the model the right number is enough to get it back.
- **Reasoning levels.** Low, medium and high effort ask whether more thinking improves the count. “None” was planned too, but GPT-6 Astra rejects it (“Reasoning is mandatory for this endpoint”), so it was dropped after the first file; the 15 rejected calls are kept in the data.
- **Highest image detail.** For the cleaned and guided prompts the image is sent with detail: “high”, the highest resolution setting OpenRouter exposes, so that low resolution cannot explain a wrong count. The image itself is never modified; an upscaled copy was considered and rejected.
- **Output cap.** Experiment 3 asks whether a tight token budget changes the answer, and at what point the answer disappears entirely.
- **Five repeats.** Five runs per condition show the spread of answers. They are not enough to estimate rates precisely, and the report does not attempt significance tests.
- **The guided prompt.** To answer the objection that the task was ambiguous, experiment 4 describes the ladder by several independent cues (bow direction, the name board, the rear deckhouse, the front mast, “closest to the camera”), says exactly what not to count (the white bar, the top knot), invites the model to explain how it counted, and asks for a machine-readable last line. The draft was corrected three times during review: an early claim that it was “the only red rope ladder” was removed, because at least five ladders have red steps; the top was described as a knot where the ladder comes to a point; and a description of the ladder as leading to the basket was reworded to position only, since these

ladders are not access ladders. Every model got its maximum reasoning setting, high image detail and a 32,000-token output cap.

- **Model choice.** Experiment 4 covers current frontier models from OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, xAI and Meta, and three open-weight models (MiniMax-M3, MiMo-V2.6-Pro, DeepSeek V4.1 Flash). A GLM model was considered, but the top GLM-5.3 model takes no image input and was left out.

What the design does not control: sampling temperature (provider defaults), the provider's internal image preprocessing, the meaning of “low” / “high” across vendors, and model version (OpenRouter does not expose one). There is one image and one human counter, and no blinding.

5. Prompts

Exact texts, as sent. The image follows the text in the same message.

`original` — Phase-1 prompt, verbatim (typos kept on purpose). Used in experiment 2.

```
I can see several rope ladders leading to the outlooks on the masts. on the front most rope ladder
how many horizoltal red steps are there to the outlook basket. return only an int like `2`
```

`example_2` — Cleaned stem, example 2. Experiment 1.

```
I can see several rope ladders leading to the outlooks on the masts. On the front-most rope ladder
how many horizontal red steps are there to the lookout basket? return only an int like `2`
```

`example_21` — Cleaned stem, example 21. Experiment 1.

```
I can see several rope ladders leading to the outlooks on the masts. On the front-most rope ladder
how many horizontal red steps are there to the lookout basket? return only an int like `21`
```

`example_11` — Cleaned stem, example 11 (the author's count). Experiments 1 and 3.

```
I can see several rope ladders leading to the outlooks on the masts. On the front-most rope ladder
how many horizontal red steps are there to the lookout basket? return only an int like `11`
```

`guided` — Guided prompt: location, exclusions, explanation and a `COUNT:` line. Experiment 4.

```
Here is a photo of a pirate ship moored at a wooden pier, seen from the pier. The bow, with the
carved figurehead and the long bowsprit, points to the left side of the photo. I want you to count
the steps (rungs) of one rope ladder: the front-most rope ladder, the one closest to the camera. It
runs diagonally from the lower right, where it is fastened to the deck in front of the raised rear
deckhouse, just to the right of the "PIRAT" name board on the hull, up to the left towards the front
mast, the mast nearest the bow. Its upper end is high on that mast, below the lookout basket. Its
steps are red horizontal ropes. At the bottom of this ladder there is a white horizontal anchoring
bar. Do not count that one. At the top, the ladder narrows and comes to a point in a knot. Do not
count that knot either. Only count the red horizontal rope steps in between. I am bad at counting.
Give me the step count and a short description of how you counted and reasoned. End your answer with
a final line in exactly this form: COUNT: <number>
```

6. Results

6.1 Overview

#	Experiment	Calls	Valid counts	API errors	Empty answers	Within ± 1	Cost
1	Reasoning level $\times$ example number	105	90	15	0	18 / 90 (20%)	\$2.47
2	Original phase-1 prompt	30	30	0	0	8 / 30 (27%)	\$0.82
3	Output cap	30	20	0	10	3 / 20 (15%)	\$0.45
4	Guided prompt, maximum reasoning	53	49	4	0	16 / 49 (33%)	\$2.74
Total		218	189	19	10	45 / 189 (24%)	\$6.48

“Valid counts” excludes API errors and empty answers. “Within ± 1 ” is out of the valid counts.

6.2 Experiments 1 and 2: reasoning level $\times$ prompt

Every condition, 5 calls each. Counts are sorted; bold marks a hit (10–12).

GPT-6 Astra

Prompt	Reasoning	Detail	Counts (sorted; bold = within 11 ± 1)	Median	Within ± 1	Mean reasoning tokens	Cost
example_2	none	high	all 5 calls rejected: HTTP 400 “Reasoning is mandatory”	–	–	–	–
example_2	low	high	12 , 13, 13, 14, 14	13	1 / 5 (20%)	253	\$0.11
example_2	medium	high	12 , 12 , 12 , 13, 13	12	3 / 5 (60%)	452	\$0.16
example_2	high	high	12 , 13, 13, 13, 13	13	1 / 5 (20%)	1,158	\$0.34
example_21	none	high	all 5 calls rejected: HTTP 400 “Reasoning is mandatory”	–	–	–	–
example_21	low	high	13, 13, 13, 14, 14	13	0 / 5 (0%)	316	\$0.13
example_21	medium	high	13, 13, 13, 14, 14	13	0 / 5 (0%)	630	\$0.21
example_21	high	high	12 , 13, 14, 14, 14	14	1 / 5 (20%)	1,348	\$0.39
example_11	none	high	all 5 calls rejected: HTTP 400 “Reasoning is mandatory”	–	–	–	–
example_11	low	high	12 , 13, 13, 13, 13	13	1 / 5 (20%)	188	\$0.10
example_11	medium	high	12 , 13, 13, 13, 13	13	1 / 5 (20%)	550	\$0.19
example_11	high	high	13, 13, 13, 13, 14	13	0 / 5 (0%)	883	\$0.27
original	low	default	12 , 13, 13, 13, 13	13	1 / 5 (20%)	238	\$0.11
original	medium	default	12 , 12 , 13, 13, 14	13	2 / 5 (40%)	636	\$0.21
original	high	default	13, 13, 13, 13, 14	13	0 / 5 (0%)	1,019	\$0.31

Claude Opus 5.5

Prompt	Reasoning	Detail	Counts (sorted; bold = within 11 ± 1)	Median	Within ± 1	Mean reasoning tokens	Cost
example_2	low	high	8, 9, 9, 12 , 13	9	1 / 5 (20%)	234	\$0.05
example_2	medium	high	9, 9, 10 , 10 , 21	10	2 / 5 (40%)	387	\$0.06
example_2	high	high	11 , 12 , 16, 17, 21	16	2 / 5 (40%)	595	\$0.08
example_21	low	high	17, 20, 22, 23, 23	22	0 / 5 (0%)	264	\$0.05
example_21	medium	high	13, 20, 24, 25, 25	24	0 / 5 (0%)	401	\$0.06
example_21	high	high	11 , 22, 23, 24, 25	23	1 / 5 (20%)	502	\$0.07
example_11	low	high	12 , 16, 20, 21, 22	20	1 / 5 (20%)	290	\$0.05
example_11	medium	high	11 , 11 , 20, 20, 22	20	2 / 5 (40%)	470	\$0.07
example_11	high	high	10 , 20, 20, 22, 23	20	1 / 5 (20%)	563	\$0.08
original	low	default	9, 9, 11 , 18, 20	11	1 / 5 (20%)	281	\$0.05
original	medium	default	9, 11 , 12 , 18, 20	12	2 / 5 (40%)	424	\$0.06
original	high	default	9, 10 , 12 , 20, 24	12	2 / 5 (40%)	537	\$0.08

By prompt (reasoning levels pooled, 15 calls per cell)

Prompt	GPT-6 Astra: median (range)	GPT-6 Astra: within ± 1	Claude Opus 5.5: median (range)	Claude Opus 5.5: within ± 1
example_2	13 (12–14)	5 / 15 (33%)	11 (8–21)	5 / 15 (33%)
example_21	13 (12–14)	1 / 15 (7%)	23 (11–25)	1 / 15 (7%)
example_11	13 (12–14)	2 / 15 (13%)	20 (10–23)	4 / 15 (27%)
original	13 (12–14)	3 / 15 (20%)	12 (9–24)	5 / 15 (33%)

By reasoning level (all four prompts pooled, 20 calls per cell)

Reasoning	GPT-6 Astra: median (range)	GPT-6 Astra: within ± 1	GPT-6 Astra: mean reasoning tokens	Claude Opus 5.5: median (range)	Claude Opus 5.5: within ± 1	Claude Opus 5.5: mean reasoning tokens
low	13 (12–14)	3 / 20 (15%)	249	16.5 (8–23)	3 / 20 (15%)	267
medium	13 (12–14)	6 / 20 (30%)	567	15.5 (9–25)	6 / 20 (30%)	421
high	13 (12–14)	2 / 20 (10%)	1,102	20 (9–25)	6 / 20 (30%)	549

6.3 Experiment 3: output cap

Prompt example_11, reasoning low, image detail default, 5 calls per cap.

Model	Output cap	Counts (sorted)	Within ± 1	Mean reasoning tokens	finish_reason	Cost
GPT-6 Astra	2,000	12 , 12 , 13, 13, 13	2 / 5 (40%)	327	stop × 5	\$0.13
GPT-6 Astra	1,000	8, 13, 14, 14, 14	0 / 5 (0%)	276	stop × 5	\$0.12
GPT-6 Astra	100	no answer in 5 of 5	–	100	length × 5	\$0.07
Claude Opus 5.5	2,000	16, 20, 24, 25, 25	0 / 5 (0%)	262	stop × 5	\$0.05

Model	Output cap	Counts (sorted)	Within ± 1	Mean reasoning tokens	finish_reason	Cost
Claude Opus 5.5	1,000	11 , 16, 17, 22, 22	1 / 5 (20%)	257	stop $\times$ 5	\$0.05
Claude Opus 5.5	100	no answer in 5 of 5	–	100	length $\times$ 5	\$0.03

6.4 Experiment 4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning

Sorted by share of hits, then by median. Gemini 3.8 Flash failed mid-generation in 4 of 8 attempts (5 at a 32k cap, 3 retried at 64k); only its valid answers are shown. Full answer texts are in Appendix A.

Model	Reasoning	Counts (sorted; bold = within 11 $\pm$ 1)	Median	Within ± 1	Mean reasoning tokens	Median latency (s)	Cost
GPT-6 Astra openai/gpt-6-astra	effort xhigh	12, 12, 12, 12, 12	12	5 / 5 (100%)	3,833	99.2	\$0.99
MiniMax-M3 minimax/minimax-m3	effort xhigh	10, 10, 10, 12 , 14	10	4 / 5 (80%)	660	5.8	\$0.0057
GPT-6.1 Sol openai/gpt-6.1-sol	effort xhigh	12, 12 , 13, 13, 13	13	2 / 5 (40%)	4,188	78.2	\$0.22
MiMo-V2.6-Pro xiaomi/mimo-v2.6-pro	effort xhigh	11, 12 , 18, 19, 20	18	2 / 5 (40%)	3,327	91.3	\$0.02
DeepSeek V4.1 Flash deepseek/deepseek-v4.1-flash	effort xhigh	12 , 13, 15, 16, 20	15	1 / 5 (20%)	10,801	28.0	\$0.06
Claude Fable 5.1 anthropic/claude-fable-5.1	thinking budget 24,000	11 , 13, 17, 17, 20	17	1 / 5 (20%)	863	22.8	\$0.38
Claude Opus 5.5 anthropic/claude-opus-5.5	thinking budget 24,000	10 , 19, 20, 20, 22	20	1 / 5 (20%)	552	14.5	\$0.13
Gemini 3.8 Flash google/gemini-3.8-flash	effort xhigh	9, 13, 13, 13, +4 none	13	0 / 4 (0%)	31,673	232.2	\$0.48
Grok 4.7 x-ai/grok-4.7	effort xhigh	15, 16, 16, 22, 23	16	0 / 5 (0%)	8,652	91.5	\$0.27
Muse Spark 1.3 meta/muse-spark-1.3	effort xhigh	23, 24, 26, 28, 35	26	0 / 5 (0%)	8,839	64.7	\$0.20
All ten models		49 valid of 53 calls	13	16 / 49 (33%)	6,842	61.0	\$2.74

6.5 Failed and empty calls

Model	Prompt	Reasoning	Output cap	Calls	What happened
GPT-6 Astra	example_2	none	2,100	5	HTTP 400: Reasoning is mandatory for this endpoint and cannot be disabled.
GPT-6 Astra	example_11	none	2,100	5	HTTP 400: Reasoning is mandatory for this endpoint and cannot be disabled.
GPT-6 Astra	example_21	none	2,100	5	HTTP 400: Reasoning is mandatory for this endpoint and cannot be disabled.

Model	Prompt	Reasoning	Output cap	Calls	What happened
GPT-6 Astra	example_11	low	100	5	Empty answer, finish_reason "length": the whole cap went to reasoning.
Claude Opus 5.5	example_11	low	100	5	Empty answer, finish_reason "length": the whole cap went to reasoning.
Gemini 3.8 Flash	guided	xhigh	32,000	3	Provider error mid-generation (finish_reason "error"); not billed.
Gemini 3.8 Flash	guided	xhigh	64,000	1	Provider error mid-generation (finish_reason "error"); not billed.

7. Observations

- **Consistent is not correct.** GPT-6 Astra's answers sit in a narrow band (12–14, one outlier of 8) under every prompt and reasoning level, with a median of 13. In phase 1 the same prompt gave mostly 12; here, a week later, mostly 13. Its only fully correct condition is the guided prompt, where it answered 12 five times, which is within tolerance but still one more than the author's count.
- **The example number leaks into Claude Opus 5.5's count.** Its median is 11 with 2, 23 with 21 and 20 with 11. The 2 and 21 examples pull the answers towards themselves. Giving it the true count as the example did not bring it back: with 11 its median is 20. GPT-6 Astra's answers barely move with the example.
- **More reasoning did not help.** For both models, going from low to high effort roughly doubles or quadruples the reasoning tokens (see the pooled table in 6.2) without raising the share of hits or narrowing the spread. In experiment 4 the models that reasoned longest (Gemini 3.8 Flash, Muse Spark 1.3, Grok 4.7, DeepSeek V4.1 Flash) are not the most accurate.
- **The guided prompt did not settle it.** With a precise description and the maximum settings, 16 / 49 (33%) valid answers are within 11 ± 1 . Several models still answer in the high teens or twenties.
- **Explanations are not evidence.** In Appendix A, answers of 20 and more describe the same kind of careful, step-by-step count as answers of 11 or 12. The explanation text does not reveal which counts are wrong.
- **A 100-token cap gives no answer at all.** Both models spend the whole budget on reasoning and return an empty answer with finish_reason: "length", while still being billed for the tokens.

8. Limitations

- One image and one question. Nothing here generalises beyond counting thin, repeated structures in a single 1024×768 photo.
- Five runs per condition show spread, not precise rates. No significance tests were run.
- The ground truth is one person's count, and the ± 1 tolerance was set after phase 1.
- Reasoning levels are mapped by OpenRouter to each vendor's own settings, so the same label is not the same effort across models. Compare the logged reasoning tokens instead.
- detail: "high" is an OpenAI-style field; whether other providers honour it is not documented.

- Models change behind a fixed name. OpenRouter does not expose a model version, so a re-run may differ, as GPT-6 Astra's shift from 12 to 13 between phases shows.
- Only the final answers were stored, not the models' hidden reasoning. Appendix A shows the explanation each model chose to write, which is not a trace of how the number was produced.

9. Replication

The repository holds the scripts, the photo and every raw response. With Python 3.10+ and an OpenRouter key in `OPENROUTER_API_KEY`, each experiment is one command (see the README); every command is a dry run until `--run` is added. `scripts/build_metadata.py` rebuilds `data/manifest.json` and `data/calls.csv`, and `scripts/build_report.py` rebuilds this report from the same data.

Appendix A. Answers to the guided prompt

Every experiment-4 call, as returned by the model: the count, the explanation it gave, and the settings. These are the visible answers, not the hidden reasoning, which the API did not return. Grouped by model; within a model, in the order the calls were made.

GPT-6 Astra openai/gpt-6-astra

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 1,484 reasoning tokens · 39.7 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

I count ****12 red rope steps****. I followed the nearest diagonal ladder from bottom to top, counting each red horizontal rung once and excluding the white anchoring bar and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 12

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 2,444 reasoning tokens · 61.0 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

I count ****12 red rope steps****. I followed the closest diagonal ladder from bottom to top, counting each red horizontal cross-rope once, excluding the white anchoring bar and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 12

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 6,173 reasoning tokens · 166.1 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

I count ****12 red rope steps****. I followed the closest ladder from bottom to top, counting each red cross-rope once and excluding the white anchoring bar and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 12

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 5,010 reasoning tokens · 130.2 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

I count ****12 red horizontal rope steps****. I followed the nearest ladder from bottom to top, counting each red cross-rope once and excluding both the white anchoring bar and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 12

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 4,054 reasoning tokens · 99.2 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

I count ****12 red rope steps****. I followed the closest ladder upward, counting each red horizontal cross-rope once, excluding the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 12

GPT-6.1 Sol openai/gpt-6.1-sol

Count **13** · 6,194 reasoning tokens · 133.7 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

I count ****13 red rope steps****. I followed the nearest diagonal ladder from bottom to top, counting each red horizontal rope once and excluding the white anchoring bar and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 13

Count **13** · 3,346 reasoning tokens · 72.4 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

I count ****13 steps****. I followed the closest ladder from bottom to top, counting each red horizontal rope once, excluding the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot at the top.

COUNT: 13

Count **13** · 2,672 reasoning tokens · 58.1 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

I count ****13 steps****. I followed the closest diagonal ladder from bottom to top, counting each red horizontal rope once. I excluded the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 13

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 5,057 reasoning tokens · 110.3 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

I count ****12 red rope steps****. I followed the closest diagonal ladder from bottom to top, counting each red cross-rope once and excluding the white anchoring bar and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 12

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 3,670 reasoning tokens · 78.2 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

I count ****12 red rope steps****. I followed the closest ladder upward, counting each red horizontal rung once and excluding the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the pointed knot at the top.

COUNT: 12

Claude Opus 5.5 anthropic/claude-opus-5.5

Count **10** (within ± 1) · 525 reasoning tokens · 13.9 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

****Count: 10 red rope steps****

****How I counted:****

- **Found the ladder:**** The front-most red rope ladder starts at the deck just right of the "PIRAT" name board. It rises diagonally up and to the left, past the front of the raised rear deckhouse, toward the front mast.
- **Set the bottom limit:**** The white horizontal anchoring bar at the base is excluded.
- **Set the top limit:**** Above the deckhouse roof, the ladder's two side ropes converge toward the mast and meet in a knot. That narrow upper section shows no clear red cross-ropes, and the knot is excluded too.
- **Counted the red horizontal ropes in between:**** I went one by one from just above the white bar upward. The steps are roughly evenly spaced. As a cross-check, the length of the rung-bearing section divided by the typical step spacing also gives about 10.

****Caveat:**** The ropes are thin and the upper steps are small and partly overlap other rigging, so the exact number is uncertain. It could be off by one, most likely 11.

COUNT: 10

Count **20** · 475 reasoning tokens · 14.5 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

****Count: about 20 steps.**** Please treat this as an estimate. At this resolution the thin red ropes are hard to tell apart, especially near the top, so the true number could be one or two higher or lower.

****How I counted:****

- **The ladder:**** It runs from its white anchoring bar on the deck, just right of the "PIRAT" board (around the lower-right railing), up and to the left. It ends at a knot on the front mast, below the lookout basket.
- **Exclusions:**** As you asked, I skipped the white bar at the bottom and the knotted point at the top.
- **Lower half:**** Here the ladder crosses the dark deckhouse, and the red rungs stand out clearly. I counted them one by one from the bottom up and got about 10. They are spaced fairly evenly.
- **Upper half:**** Here the ladder narrows toward the mast and is seen against the sky. The rungs are thinner and harder to separate, but they keep roughly the same spacing, which gives about 10 more before the ladder closes into the knot.
- **Check:**** The ladder's full height divided by the typical gap between rungs also gives about 19–20, which matches the direct count.

If you can zoom in on a higher-resolution version, count the upper section again. That is where any error is most likely.

COUNT: 20

Count **19** · 718 reasoning tokens · 17.7 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

Rope ladder step count: about 19 red rungs (an estimate, not an exact count)

At this resolution I can't count the rungs one by one, especially near the top where the ladder narrows. So I estimated the count from the ladder's length and the spacing between rungs.

How I counted and reasoned:

1. **Finding the ladder:** I followed the red ladder from its bottom, just right of the "PIRAT" board in front of the rear deckhouse, up and to the left toward the front mast. It ends in a point below the lookout basket.
2. **Setting the ends:** I left out the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot at the top, as you asked.
3. **Spacing:** In the lower half the rungs are clear. They sit roughly evenly, about 17 pixels apart vertically in the photo.
4. **Length:** From just above the white bar (around the deck rail) to just below the knot (near the lookout basket), the ladder spans about 345 pixels vertically.
5. **Calculation:** $345 \div 17$ gives about 20 intervals. That works out to about 19 rungs between the bar and the knot.
6. **Upper section:** Near the top the rungs get short and thin against the sky and rigging, so I assumed the same spacing continues there.

The true number is probably within one or two of 19. If you can zoom into the original photo, a good way to check is to count the clear lower rungs in groups of five, then carry on upward.

COUNT: 19

Count **22** · 483 reasoning tokens · 14.4 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

Estimated step count: about 22 (probably 21-23; I can't be sure of the exact number from this photo).

How I counted and reasoned:

1. **Identifying the ladder:** I followed the front-most rope ladder from its bottom, just right of the "PIRAT" name board and in front of the raised rear deckhouse, up and to the left toward the front mast, ending below the lookout basket.
2. **Excluding the ends:** I left out the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot where the ladder narrows to a point at the top.
3. **Lower section:** From the anchoring bar up to about the level of the deckhouse roof, the red rungs are fairly easy to see against the dark deckhouse. They are evenly spaced, and I counted roughly 10 of them.
4. **Upper section:** Above the deckhouse roof, the ladder climbs against the sky and narrows, and the rungs become thin and hard to separate. Here I partly counted and partly estimated. I assumed the rungs keep roughly the same spacing along the ropes, which gives about 11-12 more up to the top knot.
5. **Adding up:** 10 lower plus about 12 upper gives about 22.

The upper rungs are too small and blurry at this resolution to count exactly, so the true number could be a rung or so either way. If you have a higher-resolution version, zooming in on the upper part near the mast would give a firmer count.

COUNT: 22

Count **20** · 561 reasoning tokens · 14.8 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

****Step count: about 20**** (a close estimate, likely within 1 or 2 of the true number; I can't be fully certain at this resolution).

****How I counted:****

1. ****Traced the ladder.**** It starts at the white anchoring bar on the deck just right of the "PIRAT" board and rises up and to the left to a point high on the front mast, below the lookout basket. I excluded the white bar at the bottom and the knot at the top.

2. ****Lower section (deckhouse wall up to the roof line).**** The red rungs stand out clearly against the dark wall. I counted about 9 there, evenly spaced about 15 pixels apart vertically.

3. ****Upper section (above the roof, against the sky and rigging).**** The rungs are thinner and harder to see, and they overlap other ropes, so I couldn't count each one reliably. Instead, I checked the rungs I could see against the spacing from the lower section. Assuming that spacing stays roughly constant, the remaining height up to where the ladder narrows fits about 11 more rungs.

4. ****Total.**** 9 + 11 = about 20 red rope steps between the bar and the knot.

If you can zoom in on the original photo, recounting the upper section would confirm the exact number, since that is where my uncertainty lies.

COUNT: 20

Claude Fable 5.1 anthropic/claude-fable-5.1

Count **17** · 725 reasoning tokens · 22 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

****How I counted****

I followed the front-most shroud/ratline ladder from its white anchoring bar at the bottom (just right of the "PIRAT" board, in front of the rear deckhouse) up and to the left toward the foremast, tracking the point where its two side ropes converge in a knot below the lookout basket.

- I first worked through the clearly visible lower section, between the deck and the ship's railing, where the red rungs are widest and evenly spaced. I ticked these off one at a time, from bottom to top.

- I then continued into the upper section, where the ladder narrows as it passes in front of the mast and rigging; the rungs there are shorter and closer together, so I compared each red line's position against the diagonal side ropes to make sure I only counted rungs belonging to this ladder and not the red ratlines of the second (rear) ladder behind it or the mast's rigging lines.

- I excluded the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot at the top, as requested.

Counting from bottom (just above the white bar) to top (just below the knot), I arrive at 17 red rope steps.

COUNT: 17

Count **11** (within ± 1) · 839 reasoning tokens · 21.6 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

****Count of red rope steps: 11****

How I counted: I located the front-most ladder starting at the white horizontal bar just right of the "PIRAT" board, in front of the rear deckhouse (around the lower middle-right of the photo). From that bar I followed the ladder up and to the left toward the fore mast, ticking off each red horizontal rope one at a time. The lowest steps are wide and clearly separated; as the ladder rises past the deckhouse roof and toward the mast, the steps get progressively shorter and closer together until the side ropes meet in the knot below the lookout basket. I skipped the white bar at the bottom and the terminating knot at the top, and only counted the red horizontal ropes between them, checking twice to make sure I didn't double-count the narrow upper steps.

COUNT: 11

Count **13** · 881 reasoning tokens · 23.2 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

****How I counted****

I traced the ladder from the white horizontal anchor bar (just above deck level, to the right of the "PIRAT" board and in front of the rear deckhouse) up and to the left toward the front mast. I then went rung by rung, using the fairly regular spacing of the red ropes as a check: the rungs are wide and clearly separated in the lower part (in front of the dark hull and railing), and become shorter and closer together as the two side ropes converge toward the knot just below the lookout basket on the front mast.

- Lower section (from the white bar up to about railing height): 8 red rungs, wide and easy to distinguish.
- Upper, narrowing section (above the railing, against the sky/mast up to the knot): 5 more red rungs, progressively shorter.

I excluded the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot at the top, as requested. Checking the total against the even spacing of the rungs over the ladder's length gave a consistent result.

COUNT: 13

Count **17** · 920 reasoning tokens · 22.8 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

****How I counted****

I followed the front ratline (the rope ladder from the deck just right of the "PIRAT" board up-left to the foremast) from bottom to top and split it into two sections to keep track:

1. ****Lower section**** (from the white anchoring bar up to about the height of the ship's rail): here the red rungs are close together and clearly visible against the dark hull/deckhouse. I counted ****9**** red rungs in this stretch.
2. ****Upper section**** (from the rail height up to where the ladder narrows to the knot on the mast, below the lookout basket): the rungs are seen against the sky and the mast rigging, and become progressively shorter as the shrouds converge. I counted ****8**** red rungs here, the last few being very short just under the terminating knot.

I excluded the white horizontal bar at the bottom and the pointed knot at the top, as requested. I also made sure not to count the diagonal shroud ropes or the mast's other rigging lines that cross behind the ladder - only the horizontal red ropes belonging to this ladder.

Total: $9 + 8 = 17$ red rope steps.

COUNT: 17

Count **20** · 951 reasoning tokens · 24.0 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

****Step count: about 20 red rungs.****

How I counted and reasoned:

1. ****Locating the ladder.**** I followed the shroud that leaves the deck just right of the "PIRAT" name board, in front of the raised rear deckhouse (around the white anchoring bar at its foot), and runs up-left to the front mast, ending in a converging point/knot below the crow's nest. This is the ladder nearest the camera; the ladders on the rear mast and the second set behind it were ignored.
2. ****Splitting into two sections.**** The ladder naturally divides into a lower part seen against the dark deckhouse/hull (where the red rungs contrast strongly) and an upper part seen against the sky (where the ladder narrows toward the mast).
3. ****Lower section (against the deckhouse, from the white bar up to the ship's rail):**** I counted the red horizontal lines one by one, using the deckhouse windows and rail as reference marks – 9 rungs.
4. ****Upper section (against the sky, from the rail up to the knot):**** the rungs are evenly spaced (about the same pitch as below) and I counted them along the shroud lines up to where the side ropes pinch together – 11 rungs.
5. ****Total:**** $9 + 11 = 20$, excluding the white bar at the bottom and the knot at the top. Because the image resolution is limited where the rungs are thinnest near the top, the true figure could be off by one (19-21), but 20 is my best count.

COUNT: 20

Gemini 3.8 Flash google/gemini-3.8-flash

No answer · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

provider error mid-generation

No answer · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

provider error mid-generation

No answer · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

provider error mid-generation

Count **13** · 30,716 reasoning tokens · 198.8 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

To count the steps (rungs) of the front-most rope ladder, we trace the ladder from the white anchoring bar at the bottom to the apex knot at the top:

1. ****Ladder Location & Boundaries**:**
 - The ladder is located on the waist of the ship on the starboard/pier-facing side, just forward of the rear deckhouse and to the right of the hull's "PIRAT" nameplate.
 - At the bottom, it anchors to a white horizontal bar at deck/rail level (excluded from the count).
 - At the top, the ladder's outer ropes narrow into a pointed apex knot (also excluded from the count) from which stays run up towards the foremast.
2. ****Counting the Rungs**:**
 - ****Bottom section (below the grey tarp):**** Above the white anchoring bar against the darker deck/hull, there are ****2**** horizontal red rope rungs.
 - ****Middle section (in front of the grey tarp):**** Against the bright grey canvas/tarp on deck, the red rope grid is clearly visible with ****6**** evenly spaced horizontal red rope rungs crossing it.
 - ****Top section (above the grey tarp to the knot):**** Moving up from the top edge of the tarp towards the apex knot as the ladder tapers inward, there are ****5**** progressively narrower horizontal red rope rungs.

Adding these together: $2 + 6 + 5 = 13$ horizontal red rope rungs in total.

COUNT: 13

Count **13** · 28,823 reasoning tokens · 229.0 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

To count the steps (rungs) of the front-most rope ladder:

1. **Locating the ladder**: The ladder begins at the deck railing just to the right of the "PIRAT" name board, anchored to a white horizontal bar, and angles upward and forward (to the left) in front of the raised deckhouse toward the foremast, tapering to a knot at its upper apex before the stays continue up to the mast.
2. **Excluding endpoints**: As instructed, we exclude the white horizontal anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot/apex at the top.
3. **Counting the red horizontal rope steps from bottom to top**:
 - **Lower section** (in front of the grey tarp covering the deck equipment): Starting just above the white anchoring bar, there are **6** evenly spaced red horizontal rungs spanning across the shrouds up to the top edge of the tarp.
 - **Middle section** (in front of the deckhouse wall and front windows): Just above the tarp, across the lower sill and the window area of the deckhouse, there are **5** red horizontal rungs.
 - **Upper section** (at and above the roofline): There is **1** rung level with the roofline/overhang and **1** final, short rung just below the apex knot where the shrouds converge.

This gives a total of $6 + 5 + 2 = 13$ red horizontal rope steps.

COUNT: 13

Count **9** · 32,209 reasoning tokens · 235.5 s · cap 64,000 · repeat 0

To determine the number of steps (horizontal red rope rungs) on the front-most rope ladder, we can trace and count them systematically from the bottom anchoring bar to the top knot:

1. **Exclusions**:
 - The white horizontal metal anchoring bar at the bottom attached to the ship's gunwale is excluded.
 - The knot at the very top apex where the ropes meet and taper to a point is also excluded.
2. **Step-by-step count from bottom to top**:
 - **Rung 1**: The lowest red horizontal rope spanning across the vertical lines just above the white anchoring bar.
 - **Rungs 2, 3, and 4**: The next three red horizontal rungs ascending evenly across the lower section (in front of the grey protective tarp).
 - **Rung 5**: The horizontal red rope positioned roughly at the level of the upper edge of the grey tarp.
 - **Rungs 6, 7, and 8**: The next three red horizontal ropes continuing upward against the dark background of the deckhouse structure.
 - **Rung 9**: The uppermost, shortest horizontal red rope step located directly below the apex knot where the ladder tapers to a point.

Counting all of the red horizontal rope rungs between the bottom white bar and the top knot gives a total of 9 steps.

COUNT: 9

No answer · cap 64,000 · repeat 1

provider error mid-generation (Google); completion_tokens=2771

Count **13** · 34,944 reasoning tokens · 239.9 s · cap 64,000 · repeat 2

To count the steps (rungs) of the front-most red rope ladder, we trace it from the bottom anchoring bar up to the knot at the top:

1. **Bottom Section (in front of the grey protective tarp):**

- Just above the white horizontal anchoring bar fastened near the deck, the first red horizontal rope step begins.
- Counting upward across the lower portion in front of the grey tarp, there are **6** evenly spaced red horizontal rope steps (with the 6th located right near the upper edge of the tarp).

2. **Upper Section (in front of the deckhouse front wall and windows):**

- Continuing upward as the ladder narrows towards its apex, there are **7** more red horizontal rope steps extending up the dark front of the deckhouse to just below the top knot where the shrouds converge.

Adding both sections together: 6 steps + 7 steps = 13 steps.

COUNT: 13

Grok 4.7 x-ai/grok-4.7

Count **23** · 6,110 reasoning tokens · 91.5 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

The front-most rope ladder is the diagonal one just right of the "PIRAT" board, running from the deck up toward the foremast beneath the lookout basket. I ignored the white anchoring bar at its foot and the converging knot at the top, and counted only the red horizontal rope rungs between them, moving upward from the lowest red rung. COUNT: 23

Count **16** · 10,840 reasoning tokens · 174.4 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

I followed the nearest red rope ladder from the deck up toward the foremast, excluding the white bottom anchoring bar and the top knot. Counting only the red horizontal rope rungs between them gives 16.

COUNT: 16

Count **16** · 19,111 reasoning tokens · 289.3 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

I counted the red horizontal rope rungs on the closest ladder, excluding the white bottom bar and the top knot. COUNT: 16

Count **15** · 3,283 reasoning tokens · 72.8 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

The nearest rope ladder is the red-rung one just right of the "PIRAT" board, running diagonally up-left from the deck to the foremast below the lookout basket. I ignored the white anchoring bar at the deck and the closing knot at the top, and counted only the red horizontal rope steps between them, moving upward along the ladder.

COUNT: 15

Count **22** · 3,917 reasoning tokens · 59.2 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

COUNT: 22

Muse Spark 1.3 meta/muse-spark-1.3Count **26** · 5,452 reasoning tokens · 56.5 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

The ladder is the reddish diagonal shroud on the near side, bottom fastened just right of the PIRAT board, top meeting the fore-mast below the basket.

I started just above the thick white horizontal anchoring bar and did not count it, then followed the two converging side ropes up-left toward the mast, ticking off every red horizontal intersecting rope. I grouped them in 5s going up to keep track and double-checked against the sky background. I stopped before the final converging point-knot at the top and did not count that knot.

Bottom 5 clear, then 5, then 5, then 5, then 6 very close together near the top = 26 red steps in between.
COUNT: 26

Count **28** · 6,309 reasoning tokens · 62.7 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

I found the diagonal red-runged shroud on the right side, running from the deck just right of the PIRAT board up-left to the fore-mast below the crow's nest.

I excluded the white horizontal bar at the very bottom and the converging point/knot at the very top. Then I traced the two side ropes from bottom to top and counted each distinct red horizontal rope between them in order, 1-by-1 from the wide bottom rungs to the very short top rungs, and checked again top-down.

That gives 28 red steps in between.
COUNT: 28

Count **35** · 13,300 reasoning tokens · 145.4 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

I identified the correct ladder as the steep red-sided rope ladder that starts just to the right of the PIRAT board in front of the stern deckhouse and runs up-left to the foremast below the crow's-nest.

I excluded the thick white horizontal bar at the very bottom and excluded the converging point/knot at the very top. Then I traced the two diagonal side ropes from bottom to top and counted every red horizontal rope connecting them in order, checking in small groups of 5 to avoid losing place, lower section against the hull, middle against the deckhouse, upper against the sky.

I get 35 red steps in between.

COUNT: 35

Count **24** · 6,887 reasoning tokens · 64.7 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

I isolated the red diagonal ladder on the right side - bottom just right of the PIRAT board, top high on the front mast below the basket.

I excluded the thick white anchoring bar at the bottom and the converging point/knot at the top. Then enlarging the ladder area I traced the center line from bottom to top and tallied each red horizontal rope crossing it, in groups of 5 to avoid losing place, then re-checked top-down.

Bottom white bar - excluded
1-5 just above white up to hull rail,
6-10 up past deckhouse,
11-15 up to about cannon/spotlight level,
16-20 up through mid-rigging,
21-24 getting very short up to just below the apex,
apex knot - excluded.

That gives 24 red steps in between.
COUNT: 24

Count **23** · 12,246 reasoning tokens · 140.4 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

I identified the diagonal red-sided ladder on the right side of the image.

Its foot is the white bar low on the right, just to the right of the PIRAT board, and it runs up-left to the fore-mast below the crow's-nest basket.

I excluded the bottom white anchoring bar and excluded the converging point/knot at the very top.

Starting with the first red horizontal just above the white bar, I followed the two side ropes upward and tallied every red horizontal cross-rope in order, in groups of 5 to avoid losing place, then checked back down from the top.

That gives only the red intermediate steps between the white bar and the top knot.

COUNT: 23

MiniMax-M3 minimax/minimax-m3

Count **10** (within ± 1) · 447 reasoning tokens · 5.8 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

Looking at the front-most rope ladder in the image, I can trace it from the white anchoring bar at the bottom (which I exclude) up to the knot at the top (which I also exclude).

The ladder runs diagonally upward to the left along the front mast. I counted the red horizontal rope steps by working from just above the white anchoring bar at the lower right, moving up one rung at a time toward the narrowing point near the top.

Carefully counting each distinct red horizontal rope rung between the white bar and the knot:

1 (lowest, just above the white bar), 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10 (highest, just below where the ladder narrows to a point).

I reasoned that because the rungs are evenly spaced and the ladder is foreshortened by perspective, I needed to count each one individually rather than estimating, paying close attention to the spaces between rungs to avoid double-counting or missing one near the narrowing point.

COUNT: 10

Count **10** (within ± 1) · 1,737 reasoning tokens · 13.8 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

Looking at the photo, I need to identify the specific rope ladder described. The bow is on the left with the figurehead and bowsprit, and the "PIRAT" name board is on the hull. Just to the right of that board, I can see a rope ladder running diagonally upward to the left toward the front mast (the one with the crow's nest/lookout basket).

****How I counted:****

I located the ladder by its anchor points: starting at the deck to the right of the "PIRAT" board and ending high on the front mast below the lookout basket. I excluded the white horizontal bar at the very bottom (the anchoring bar) and the knot at the very top. I then counted only the red horizontal rope rungs in between, going from the lowest red rung up to the highest red rung before the final narrowing knot.

Starting from just above the white anchor bar and moving up along the diagonal toward the mast, I can identify roughly evenly spaced red horizontal rope steps. Tracing them carefully – the spacing between rungs stays fairly consistent, helping confirm each step. Counting them sequentially: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10. The upper end narrows into a knot, which I stop counting at.

My reasoning: the ladder has a relatively uniform rung spacing, and I traced it carefully without skipping any, treating any ambiguous areas conservatively.

COUNT: 10

Count **10** (within ± 1) · 372 reasoning tokens · 5.9 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

Looking at the front-most rope ladder, I can trace it from the lower right (where it meets the deck near the PIRAT board, above the white anchoring bar) running diagonally up-left toward the front mast.

****How I counted:****

- I started at the lowest red horizontal rope step, just above the white anchoring bar at the bottom of the ladder.
- I moved upward along the ladder, counting each distinct red horizontal rope rung.
- I stopped counting before the ladder narrows and tapers into the knot at the top.

Working from bottom to top along the diagonal, I can identify ****10**** distinct red horizontal rope steps between the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the tapered knot at the top.

COUNT: 10

Count **14** · 349 reasoning tokens · 5.1 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

Looking at the front-most rope ladder, I traced it from the white anchoring bar at the bottom (excluded) up to the knot at the top (excluded), counting only the red horizontal rope steps in between.

****How I counted and reasoned:****

- I located the ladder's lower anchor point near the deck, just right of the "PIRAT" name board, where the white horizontal bar is tied off (skipped).
- From there, I followed the two side ropes diagonally up-left toward the front mast, stopping where the ladder narrows into the terminal knot (skipped).
- I counted each red horizontal rope crossing the side ropes, working bottom-to-top, taking care not to double-count any that overlap due to the diagonal perspective or merge with rigging lines.
- I re-counted top-to-bottom as a check to confirm consistency.
- I disregarded the red/pink halyard and other rigging ropes near the mast that are parallel to the ladder – only the rungs spanning the ladder's two side ropes were counted.

My careful count of the red horizontal rope steps is ****14****.

COUNT: 14

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 396 reasoning tokens · 5.2 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

Looking at the rope ladder running diagonally from the deck near the "PIRAT" signboard up to the front mast, I can identify the red horizontal rope steps by tracing along the two side ropes of the ladder.

****Counting method:**** I started at the bottom of the ladder just above the white anchoring bar, then carefully traced each red horizontal rope rung going upward, following the diagonal trajectory until the ladder narrows into the knot at the top. I counted each distinct red step as a separate horizontal element crossing between the two vertical side ropes.

Going from bottom to top:

1 (just above white bar), 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12 (just below the narrowing knot)

The steps are evenly spaced along the diagonal run, and the white bar at the base plus the terminal knot at the top are excluded as instructed.

COUNT: 12

MiMo-V2.6-Pro xiaomi/mimo-v2.6-proCount **11** (within ± 1) · 917 reasoning tokens · 31.6 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

To count the steps of the ladder, I identified the specific rope ladder you described: the one closest to the camera, anchored near the "PIRAT" name board and ascending diagonally to the front mast.

1. ****Locating the start:**** At the bottom of the ladder, there is a white horizontal anchoring bar. Following your instructions, I did not count this bar.
2. ****Counting the red rungs:**** Starting immediately above the white bar, I counted the horizontal red rope rungs going upwards.
 - * Rung 1 is the lowest red rung.
 - * Rungs 2 through 8 follow in fairly even spacing up the diagonal line.
 - * As the ladder approaches the mast and narrows, Rungs 9, 10, and 11 continue upwards.
3. ****Locating the end:**** Immediately above the 11th rung, the black side ropes converge and are tied off in a knot where the ladder attaches to the mast. Following your instructions, I did not count this knot.

There are exactly 11 distinct horizontal red rope rungs in between the bottom white bar and the top knot.

COUNT: 11

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 2,625 reasoning tokens · 82.4 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

Based on the image and your description, here is how I counted the steps:

1. ****Locate the ladder**:** I identified the specific rope ladder starting at the bottom right, attached to the deck just to the right of the "PIRAT" name board, and extending diagonally up to the left towards the front mast.
2. ****Start point**:** I found the white horizontal anchoring bar at the very bottom where the ladder is attached to the deck. Following your instructions, I excluded this from the count.
3. ****Counting up**:** Moving upwards along the ladder, I counted each red horizontal rope step.
 - * The first red step is just above the white bar.
 - * Continuing up past the dark wooden structure of the deckhouse and into the open area towards the mast, I counted the subsequent red ropes.
4. ****End point**:** I counted 12 distinct red ropes before reaching the top of the ladder. At the very top, the ladder's side ropes converge into a narrowing point and a knot. I excluded this knot from the count as instructed.

The total count of red horizontal rope steps is 12.

COUNT: 12

Count **20** · 2,265 reasoning tokens · 91.3 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

To count the steps of the rope ladder, I focused on the ladder located on the right side of the image, which connects the deck to the front mast.

I started at the bottom of the ladder where it is anchored to the deck. As noted, there is a white horizontal bar at the very bottom; I excluded this from the count. Starting immediately above the white bar, I counted each red horizontal rope step moving upwards diagonally.

The ladder consists of 20 distinct red rope rungs. The spacing between the rungs is fairly consistent. As I reached the top, I stopped counting just before the point where the ladder narrows and the ropes converge into the knot, which was also excluded as per your instructions.

COUNT: 20

Count **19** · 3,443 reasoning tokens · 91.3 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

To determine the number of steps on the specific rope ladder described, I followed these steps:

1. **Identification**: I located the rope ladder in the foreground that stretches diagonally from the lower right deck area (near the "PIRAT" name board) up to the left towards the front mast (the one with the basket/crow's nest).
2. **Exclusions**: As instructed, I identified and disregarded the white horizontal anchoring bar at the bottom and the knot at the very top of the ladder where the lines converge.
3. **Counting**: I counted the red horizontal rope rungs located strictly between the white bar and the top knot.
 - * Starting just above the white bar at the bottom, I counted upwards:
 - * There is a series of clearly defined red rungs.
 - * Counting each red horizontal segment individually from bottom to top results in 19 distinct rungs.
 - * The 19th rung is the last visible red line just before the knot at the top.

The total count of red horizontal rope steps is 19.

COUNT: 19

Count **18** · 7,387 reasoning tokens · 200.8 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

Based on the image provided and your detailed description, I have counted the steps of the front-most rope ladder.

Reasoning and Counting Method:

1. **Identification**: I located the ladder as the one running diagonally up the front mast, situated to the right of the "PIRAT" sign and the hull.
2. **Exclusions**: I identified the "white horizontal anchoring bar" at the bottom and the "knot" at the top where the ropes converge. As requested, I did not count these.
3. **Counting**: I focused on the red horizontal ropes ("steps") situated between these two anchors. Starting from the very first red rope immediately above the white bottom bar and counting upwards to the last red rope just below the top knot, I counted each step one by one.
4. **Result**: The count proceeds through the ladder sections: there are 18 distinct red horizontal ropes in the middle section.

COUNT: 18

DeepSeek V4.1 Flash deepseek/deepseek-v4.1-flash

Count **13** · 10,509 reasoning tokens · 27.5 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 0

I counted the red horizontal rope rungs along the near, diagonal rope ladder, starting just above the white horizontal bottom bar and stopping below the top knot where the ladder narrows. Excluding the white anchoring bar at the bottom and the top knot, I counted the red rungs in between as 13.

COUNT: 13

Count **12** (within ± 1) · 10,173 reasoning tokens · 95.9 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 1

I located the front-most rope ladder on the near side of the foremast, starting above the white horizontal anchoring bar near the "PIRAT" name board and extending up toward the foremast below the lookout basket. I counted each red horizontal rope step between the excluded white bottom bar and the excluded top knot. My count was 12 red rungs.

COUNT: 12

Count **20** · 16,611 reasoning tokens · 49.3 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 2

The front-most rope ladder is the diagonal one on the near side, with red horizontal rungs. I started counting just above the white anchoring bar at the bottom and counted each red horizontal rope step upward, stopping just below the pointed/knot at the top. I did not count the white base bar or the top knot.

COUNT: 20

Count **16** · 10,609 reasoning tokens · 28.0 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 3

I counted the red horizontal rope rungs on the front-most ladder, starting from the first red rung just above the white anchoring bar and ending at the last red rung just below the narrowing top knot. I did not count the white bottom anchoring bar or the top knot.

COUNT: 16

Count **15** · 6,104 reasoning tokens · 18.1 s · cap 32,000 · repeat 4

I counted the red horizontal rope steps on the front-most ladder by tracing from the bottom up. I skipped the white anchoring bar at the very bottom and stopped before the top knot where the ladder narrows. In between, I counted 15 red rungs.

COUNT: 15

Appendix B. Raw files

SHA-256 checksums of the raw files in `data/raw/`, as listed in `data/manifest.json` (total 218 calls, 19 API errors, \$6.48).

File (data/raw/)	Contents	Calls	Errors	Cost	SHA-256
reasoning-20260930-042404.jsonl	1: GPT-6 Astra, prompts example_2/21/11 x reasoning none/low/medium/high (none is rejected by the API)	60	15	\$1.90	1bec586dc3255dd6c1ea01aa5613bcef29638c948da05d8121054db3c0f8c742
reasoning-20260930-043124.jsonl	2: GPT-6 Astra, original phase-1 prompt, default image detail, low/medium/high	15	0	\$0.62	a5a34dda541359a03d14976f2cad75d6026b62442fe77569094560898ea6a089
reasoning-20260930-043624.jsonl	1: Claude Opus 5.5, prompts example_2/21/11 x reasoning low/medium/high	45	0	\$0.57	275ac5c2849a5d61bca1af5408872240c24fdf483bedab64ae838a309fee5358
reasoning-20260930-043804.jsonl	2: Claude Opus 5.5, original phase-1 prompt, default image detail, low/medium/high	15	0	\$0.19	3dd22c5d3faa8cd164e8be058df76c3c42e33a367ea0d8ac1128a5c47e94ac27
reasoning-20260930-044245.jsonl	3: output-cap test, example_11, low reasoning, default detail	5	0	\$0.13	d3b5480af0eef106c5d9caeebf25b4ec7b897a8f778490c5782215583ac5547
reasoning-20260930-044310.jsonl	3: output-cap test, example_11, low reasoning, default detail	5	0	\$0.12	837cf1a12c0f15d0e3c2f29cf9d265d49a64bbd3489e78f4ab8da979a24502bb
reasoning-20260930-044333.jsonl	3: output-cap test, example_11, low reasoning, default detail	5	0	\$0.07	63b3e85a60ea4b485cba1d7352017b022804af4fe39bba1d60e69548390df25c
reasoning-20260930-044350.jsonl	3: output-cap test, example_11, low reasoning, default detail	5	0	\$0.05	800ac12505a8394502e8ea63652b931ab7e7f75b08e9eeefa380556fb00104d9
reasoning-20260930-044406.jsonl	3: output-cap test, example_11, low reasoning, default detail	5	0	\$0.05	6d03cdc807a997864f94e82ffc9fdbdbcd11c0d14d5806d6547e7dc925a0b2c1
reasoning-20260930-044424.jsonl	3: output-cap test, example_11, low reasoning, default detail	5	0	\$0.03	65db76387e69623ad161b5664822f62695ec71821366328290d6285751a9add0
reasoning-20260930-050429.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.99	cc6752229e7d3ce6fabaf2730ca4211b9c83179d5df90728c392dfe4368f196
reasoning-20260930-050855.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.13	d8a4a53c06eaf033d8599830dce14642e803490b2abef38415a340cb7c9008a0
reasoning-20260930-051532.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.38	71c02fac1c0ea22dfa6f4effa36ed468c3d3be50b34fd3b50c15af81af0bc2d9
reasoning-20260930-052556.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.0057	53f17ac6b9490958cb56d649f122ccabfdd0ac2061c16456bd61f1d2b5a953ae
reasoning-20260930-052618.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.02	26e594d7db79743f359ba086b15184ce3c4dfa989b9979639a3036fe9117294f
reasoning-20260930-053111.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.06	9a2ee4aa4e7e2cca6df04d909cf1054712f788d44bd2880c6fca72b34027c6a1
reasoning-20260930-053542.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	3	\$0.23	a851ca3e3f774c8e5e215454896c5dc2eb1ea7ace18cfc1714190fd6266a68f5
reasoning-20260930-054303.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.22	7b71239f773335792d47f0b597aaed65397ce0f3b7ede13baef4d15ca28a392c
reasoning-20260930-054735.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.20	fdcbc20fa0e24c1faa50db1c7d75d9d8b389c891fabf9d9b48e23b2f0755a3be
reasoning-20260930-055158.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	5	0	\$0.27	0ce198e5acc53c2cc4b70b460613f6593dfc56bfcc7e227566638da5159c5df5

File (data/raw/)	Contents	Calls	Errors	Cost	SHA-256
reasoning-20260930-055800.jsonl	4: guided prompt, maximum reasoning, image detail high	3	1	\$0.26	b0da927aacd2c4246cc96e2210727b77c1dfc8c0e3c3e61e749b9cdeb2aa7e56

Image data/image/ship-the-ship-haven-travel-vacation-62f2b5-1024.jpg, 1024 × 768 px, SHA-256 ced1316202c50b3d6c4088e72a3c6c18e50d7c302a04365432f01b507f408fb2.